

Typography System v1

Project Dive Log (BSAC personal PWA)

Status Decided & wired in

Direction Marine Naturalist (02 of 3 explored)

Audience Developer handoff

BACKGROUND & BRIEF

The app previously used three system-font stacks: `-apple-system` for UI, Georgia for journal content, and SF Mono/Consolas for all labels and instrument data. While functional, this produced a look indistinguishable from any other utilitarian data app — exactly what the user persona (an experienced recreational diver who journals meticulously) does not want.

The goal of this session was to explore custom typography that gives the app genuine character while remaining true to its dual nature: a precise field instrument *and* a personal journal. Three full directions were built and compared side-by-side, applied to the real Dive File screen.

"I don't want it to look like the techie style of other apps. It should have character."

DIRECTIONS EXPLORED

All three directions were applied to the live Dive File screen with colour and layout held constant, so only the type changed. All fonts are Google Fonts (open-source, self-hostable).

01 · Field Journal

Newsreader (display + journal, one calm voice) · Hanken Grotesk (UI) · IBM Plex Mono (data). Quiet and editorial — like a beautifully kept paper logbook. **Not chosen:** too understated, lacked distinctive character.

02 • Marine Naturalist CHOSEN

Young Serif (display titles) · Literata (journal prose) · Figtree (all UI and labels). Warm and characterful — field-guide-plate feel, no terminal/techie mono voice. **Chosen** as the strongest balance of personality and legibility.

03 • Modern Field Science

Space Grotesk (display + UI) · Spectral (journal) · Space Mono (data). Crisp and modern. **Not chosen**: too close to the "cockpit" techie aesthetic the persona wants to move away from.

THE CHOSEN SYSTEM — DIRECTION 02

During refinement, two iterations were made: (1) Space Grotesk was briefly trialled for the large stat numerals, then dropped in favour of Figtree for consistency. (2) Young Serif was removed from the numerals entirely when it was judged "too much" at dense-data sizes. The final system consolidates to **three families**.

DISPLAY — TITLES ONLY

Sangeang Bubble Reef

Young Serif

Single-weight (400) humanist serif. Used only at display scale: dive-site hero titles and journal entry headings. Brings field-guide-plate character without competing with reading text.

JOURNAL — READING VOICE

*The volcano, exhaling
through the sand.*

Literata

Optical-size variable serif, designed for long-form reading. Used for journal prose, scientific names in italic, and journal title/snippet previews in the history timeline.

UI & DATA — FUNCTIONAL VOICE

28.4 m 47 min VU

Figtree

Geometric humanist sans. Carries every functional surface: nav, labels, section headers, form fields, buttons, IUCN badges, timestamps, and all large stat numerals. Replaces both the old system sans and the old mono stack.

STRUCTURAL DECISION — DROPPING MONOSPACE

The previous system used a monospace font as a third "instrument" voice for all data labels, coordinates, and badges. Direction 02 **removes mono entirely**. All label and data surfaces move to Figtree, styled with small-caps, letter-spacing, and uppercase to maintain visual hierarchy without

the terminal / cockpit feeling that mono introduced.

This is a considered departure: the "field-guide" character now comes from Young Serif at the display level, not from a typewriter register in the labels. The result is warmer and more cohesive.

ROLE EXAMPLES IN CONTEXT

HERO SITE TITLE	Sangeang Bubble Reef
JOURNAL TITLE	The volcano breathes
JOURNAL PROSE	The pygmy seahorse took us twenty minutes to find. Wayan pointed at a gorgonian fan and I saw nothing but coral — until one of the ‘polyps’ turned its head.
SCIENTIFIC NAME	<i>Hippocampus bargibanti</i>
HISTORY GLIMPSE	The volcano, exhaling through the sand...
SECTION LABEL	MARINE LIFE · 6 SPECIES
STAT NUMERAL	28.4 ↓ MAX M
NAV / UI	History Species Stats

CSS TOKEN CHANGES

Four CSS custom properties in `:root` of `css/styles.css` define the entire system. All other rules consume these tokens — no font-family values appear elsewhere except in the two display-specific overrides below.

TOKEN	VALUE	USED FOR
<code>--sans</code>	<i>'Figtree', -apple-system, system-ui, sans-serif</i>	Body, nav, buttons, inputs, form fields, all UI chrome
<code>--mono</code>	<i>'Figtree', -apple-system, system-ui, sans-serif</i>	All label, badge, and data-display rules (same face as <code>--sans</code> ; retained as a separate token so the role stays explicit in the CSS and can diverge later)
<code>--serif</code>	<i>'Literata', Georgia, serif</i>	Journal body text (<code>.df-notes-body</code>), history glimpses (<code>.dh-glimpse</code> , <code>.dD-glimpse</code>), scientific name italics
<code>--display</code> NEW	<i>'Young Serif', Georgia, serif</i>	Dive-site hero title (<code>.df-site</code>) and journal entry heading (<code>.df-notes-title</code>) only. Always at font-weight: 400 — Young Serif is single-weight.

FILE-LEVEL DIFF SUMMARY

CSS/STYLES.CSS — :ROOT FONT TOKENS

```
-  --mono: ui-monospace, 'SF Mono', Menlo, Consolas, 'Liberation Mono', monospace;
-  --sans: -apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, 'Segoe UI', system-ui, sans-serif;
-  --serif: Georgia, 'Times New Roman', serif;
+  --mono: 'Figtree', -apple-system, system-ui, sans-serif;
+  --sans: 'Figtree', -apple-system, system-ui, sans-serif;
+  --serif: 'Literata', Georgia, serif;
+  --display: 'Young Serif', Georgia, serif;
```

CSS/STYLES.CSS — .DF-NOTES-TITLE

```
-  font-family: var(--serif); font-size: 22px; font-weight: 700;
+  font-family: var(--display); font-size: 22px; font-weight: 400;
```

CSS/STYLES.CSS — .DF-SITE

```
- font-size: 24px; font-weight: 700; letter-spacing: -0.02em;  
+ font-family: var(--display); font-size: 24px; font-weight: 400; letter-spacing: 0;
```

INDEX.HTML — <HEAD> — BEFORE STYLES.CSS LINK

```
+ <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com">  
+ <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.gstatic.com" crossorigin>  
+ <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Figtree:ital,wght@0,300..900;  
  &family=Literata:ital,opsz,wght@0,7..72,300..700;1,7..72,300..700  
  &family=Young+Serif&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

OUTSTANDING WORK

OFFLINE / PWA — SELF-HOSTING REQUIRED

Google Fonts loads from an external CDN. The current service worker (`sw.js`) only caches same-origin resources, so the app will fall back to Georgia / system-sans when offline. The fonts look correct on every connected load, but true offline support requires the steps below.

01 Download font files. From `fonts.google.com`, download Figtree (variable, wght 300–900), Literata (variable, opsz + wght), and Young Serif (400 only). Extract the `.woff2` files into `diver-log/fonts/`.

02 Add @font-face rules. At the top of `css/styles.css`, add `@font-face` declarations pointing to the local `/fonts/` paths. Remove or replace the Google Fonts `<link>` in `index.html` once self-hosted.

03 Update sw.js SHELL cache. Add the font file paths (e.g. `'/fonts/Figtree-variable.woff2'`) to the SHELL array in `sw.js` and bump the CACHE version string so the updated worker installs cleanly.

04 Update webdist/ for web deployment. Copy the updated `css/styles.css` and `index.html` into `webdist/` as part of your next build, or re-run the build step that generates it.

05 Apply --display to desktop overrides. The desktop media query sets `.df-notes-full` `.df-notes-title { font-size: 26px }` and `28px` — these override font-size only so Young Serif already applies, but verify visually at 900px+ breakpoint once fonts are loaded live in the app.

06 Consider --display for the History desk heading. `.dh-site` (17px, desktop history card site name) currently inherits Figtree. At a future iteration, consider whether Young Serif at that size adds character or reads too heavy in a dense list.

DESIGN INTENT — ONE-LINE SUMMARY PER ROLE

Young Serif — the moment of arrival. Only for titles that name a place or a memory; everything else must earn it before getting this face.

Literata — the interior voice. Everything the diver wrote, every scientific name, every glimpse of a note in a list. Warm, readable at length, italic-first.

Figtree — the instrument. Every number, label, badge, nav item, button, and timestamp. Friendly but precise; warm enough to match the palette without competing with the serifs.